

paign. Launched by a Facebook group that calls itself A Consortium of Pub-going Loose and Forward Women, started by a handful of members saw enrolment touch 20,000 within three days. Their campaign invites everyone to send Mutalik pink underwear on V-day, in response to his moral policing. Nisha Susan, a consortium founder writes on the site, "We plan to

MLA's daughter was accosted by Hindu activists in a bus for speaking to a Muslim boy, Acharya reprimanded the MLA instead for "not taking care of his child". But now the state government has realised that they have too much to do with a man like Mutalik if they have to keep their reputation in the BJP's trophy southern state. Yedyurappa has been very firm in his

statements about Mutalik and his Government has been arresting him for offences committed four years back. Post-Mangalore, the Government doesn't want anything to do with him and Mutalik himself admits that the friendship "has seen a 50 per cent meltdown". "The only relationship I have with the BJP is based on friendship. They are grateful to me for what I have done for the party in the state," he says, not forgetting to claim that most of the BJP MLAs elected from North Karnataka owe their victories to his efforts.



SHRI RAM SENE MEN OUTSIDE AMNESIA PUB IN MANGALORE

take pictures of ourselves in the pubs and will make giant posters and send it to the Sri Ram Sene. Caught by surprise, Mutalik says he will reciprocate by sending pink saris. Rajeev Gowda, political activist and an IIM professor, says Mutalik "has ironically woken up the educated people to fight for issues of liberal democracy. Don't try violence on us, we will retaliate".

How Mutalik, who is believed to have taken a vow of celibacy, has suddenly begun to regard Karnataka as his fiefdom is anybody's guess. Socially, his dreams of Talibanising Karnataka have been shattered somewhat after the public outrage and the widespread Pink Chaddi campaign. Chief Minister B.S. Yedyurappa and Home Minister V.S. Acharya have been oscillating between arresting Mutalik, releasing him on bail, and agreeing to his ideas once in a while. After the Mangalore incident, the state Government said that pub culture was bad for the youth. And after a Kerala

Culture Culture

- Started his career as a RSS pracharak in 1975, claims he was jailed for a month during the Emergency.
- Had been charged in 53 cases in his 33-year-old political career, of which he has been acquitted in 41.
- Quizzed by the ATS on possible links with the Malegaon blasts case.
- Arrested in Belgaum on January 27, 2009, for distributing pamphlets with provocative slogans in Davangere on January 4. Granted bail.
- Rearrested on January 28 in connection with the attack on Amnesia Pub in Mangalore on January 25, 2009. Granted conditional bail.
- Arrested under Section 153A on January 31 in connection with a case of communal instigation during a meeting held at Gonikoppal in October 2003. Granted bail.

But Mutalik is clearly revelling in all at the belated attention he is getting after, as he says, "building the Hindutva base in South India". Born to an RSS swayamsevak father in Belgaum district, Mutalik had started his political career in 1975 as an RSS pracharak, had become the state organising secretary of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad in 1993 and the state Bajrang Dal president two years later.

By 2005, however, he began to feel ideological differences with the BJP. "I had issues with Advaniji going to Jinnah's grave and then calling him secular. I also felt let down when he said he regretted the Babri Masjid demolition," he says. "Advaniji is compromising. As it is, Muslims in India are duplicate Muslims who were converted by Muslim invaders. I plan to reconvert them to Hinduism. Ditto for Christians," he says. Party sources, however, say that he was too ambitious, and that didn't bode well for them. He quit the BJP to join the Shiv Sene but found the party was "keen on promoting Kannadiga-Marathi differences". Mutalik then built the Shri Ram Sene, an apolitical force to combat his version of "social ills".

It doesn't matter to Mutalik that the entire country regards him as a nuisance. He sees himself on television everyday, and he doesn't care if it costs him his reputation. But then this self-proclaimed minister for morals has none. ■